

The Boston Globe

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GARDNER MYSTERY GETS A LITTLE MORE FODDER



BARRY CHIN/GLOBE STAFF

Conservation team members Angela Leersynder (left) and Kelsey Marino worked on the Dutch Room at the Gardner Museum.

In book, retired FBI agent points to mob involvement — and a chicken truck

By Shelley Murphy

GLOBE STAFF

Is it possible that Rembrandt's only seascape, "Christ in the Storm on the Sea of Galilee," stolen 36 years ago from the Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum in Boston, was delivered to mobsters in Philadelphia in a chicken truck?

That's what an informant told the FBI, according to a recently published book by retired FBI agent Geoffrey Kelly, who spearheaded the investigation into the theft for 22 years until retiring two years ago.

The informant, Ronnie "Meatball" Bowes, had been convicted of killing three men in Florida in the 1980s during a drug deal gone bad, then was released after an

appeals court ruled he acted in self-defense.

Yet during a meeting with Kelly and another agent in 2012, Bowes confided "he'd never been more nervous than he was during that long drive to Philly" as he and a Connecticut mob associate nicknamed "The Jackrabbit" rumbled down the highway in a poultry truck a decade earlier.

He was convinced that several cardboard boxes placed in the truck by a Connecticut mobster contained some of the stolen Gardner paintings. But he was too afraid to look.

"While Meatball never opened any of the packages, at the time he assumed that he'd just delivered The Storm to Philadelphia," Kelly wrote in his book, "Thirteen Perfect Fugitives," a reference to the 13 pieces sto-

len from the palatial museum.

The FBI announced more than a decade ago that it believed some of the stolen Gardner artwork went through organized crime circles while moving from Boston to Connecticut to Philadelphia, where the trail went cold.

But Kelly's book offers new details about the evidence gathered by the FBI leading up to that announcement, part of a first-hand account of the twists and turns in the sprawling investigation into the world's largest art heist, which remains unsolved.

"It's basically a scavenger hunt for 13 objects, and the whole world is in play," Kelly, 58, said during a recent interview. He is

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'I've probably seen some of the worst things you can see in policing, and I understand that. I'm cognizant it exists.'

POLICE COMMISSIONER MICHAEL COX

Cox says he's making police changes his way, but advocates of reform want much more

By Lea Skene

GLOBE STAFF

By 2022, two years after a nationwide reckoning in response to George Floyd's murder, Boston finally seemed ready for substantive police reform.

The city had a fledgling civilian oversight agency, a progressive mayor who campaigned on a promise of meaningful change, and a new police commissioner well positioned to carry it out.

In an interview, Commissioner Michael Cox said the department has been changing for the better. But in recent months, an unwelcome spotlight has landed on his contentious relationship with the Office of Police Accountability and Transparency, also known as OPAT. It's a messy

standoff that leaves some people scratching their heads, wondering what happened to the earlier sense of promise.

"I expected a different level of compassion and engagement," said Jamarhl Crawford, a community activist who served on the city's police reform task force in 2020. "That's what's confusing."

Even the department's biggest critics acknowledge that Boston is among the safest major cities in the nation, an accomplishment that points to effective policing. Yet the agency has also racked up scandals in recent years, from overtime fraud to other high-profile misconduct cases. And some argue that more action is needed to break down the so-called blue wall of silence.

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Security line may still be a mile long, but Logan's taking the shock out

By Christopher Muther

GLOBE STAFF

As TSA security checkpoint lines steadily grow across the country as a result of the partial government shutdown, Logan Airport has announced it is installing technology that will let passengers check TSA wait times before departing for the airport.

The system, which debuts in mid-April, will post wait times on Logan's website, smartphone app, and airline apps. Eventually, there will be screens at TSA checkpoints and other pre- and post-departure display boards that show the information as well.

The move is particularly timely because the TSA has stopped regularly updating air-

port wait times due to the shutdown. Its app (MyTSA) still provides wait-time information for Logan and other airports, but it is no longer actively monitored.

"We're trying to give people information about what to expect when they get to Logan," said Rich Davey, CEO of Massport.

The system at Logan, which is being installed by a third-party vendor, will use cameras to monitor line length and speed and transmit that information in real time.

The system is being tested in Terminal B, and if trials prove successful, it will then be rolled out to the rest of the airport next month. Similar systems are already in place at other airports.

Across the country, some

travelers have been waiting up to two hours to clear security. The slowdowns are due to the shutdown, which began Feb. 14.

Logan has seen weather-related delays, but it has yet to experience the long lines that have plagued some other airports.

"We've been fortunate," Davey said. "Obviously, that probably won't go on forever because at some point these folks are going to need to get a second job or get a job that pays. But so far they continue to come to work."

Additionally, Logan is still on track to roll out its new TSA "remote terminal" for passengers taking Logan Express from Framingham.

"Even with the current TSA shutdown, we are full steam ahead," Davey said.



DAVID L. RYAN/GLOBE STAFF

Logan is testing a system that will tell travelers how long TSA wait times are before leaving for the airport.

Founder blamed for school's finances

Board accuses him of hiding \$13m in debt as it struggles to keep Croft open

By John Hilliard

GLOBE STAFF

The founder of the private Croft School misled families and staff about the institution's financial condition for years, its directors told families Tuesday, by, for example, hiding \$13 million in debt, overspending its budget, and keeping two sets of records.

Officials are communicating with law enforcement regarding the financial issues, the board said, four days after they announced they had suspended founder Scott Given, also Croft's executive director, without pay.

"Although our educational outcomes and experiences are strong, Croft's financial position is not as we all believed it to be," the Croft board of managers said in a statement to families Tuesday that was viewed by the Globe.

Now the private school is scrambling to raise \$5 million to keep its doors open for the rest of the year and cover its payroll, as school administrators race to find a way to pay back creditors, the board told families.

Families said they are devastated that the school's future is in question, and their trusted leader is facing blame. Parents described feelings of shock and disbelief Tuesday.

But they stood by their school, they said, because of the staff who ensure children thrive.

"Everything is focused on getting the teachers paid and keeping the school operating," said Matt

CROFT SCHOOL, Page A6

Phone call got things moving on Cup standoff

Kraft reached out to chair of Foxborough Select Board

By Michael Silverman

GLOBE STAFF

FOXBOROUGH — Bill Yukna was out shopping the afternoon of March 10 when his phone rang.

On the other end was Robert Kraft.

For the first time in a months-long, high-stakes, and increasingly bitter standoff over who would pay for World Cup security costs in Foxborough, the two central figures in the dispute were speaking directly.

Within 24 hours of that call, a deal was in place that cleared the way for the entertainment license needed for seven World Cup matches at Gillette Stadium. And on Tuesday night, the Select Board closed the book on the deal in a unanimous vote.

Yukna, chair of the Foxborough Select Board, had become the symbol of the town's resistance. The retired CFO of a private equity firm with a deceptively laconic manner was representing a town of less than 19,000 that refused to front \$7.8 million in taxpayer money for security at a global tournament.

Kraft, owner of Gillette Stadium and the Patri-

FOXBOROUGH, Page C6



Businesses such as Caspian Persian Cuisine (above, ash reshteh soup) are preparing for Nowruz, the Persian New Year, at a difficult time for Iran. **G1.**

Israel killed two key Iranian security officials in a major blow to the Islamic Republic's leadership as it faces its greatest test in decades. **A4.**

JPMorganChase & Co. has finalized plans to lease 246,000 square feet at the newly finished South Station Tower, and is working to secure rights to put up a sign bearing its name. **B5.**

Republicans launched an unprecedented effort to hold the Senate floor and talk for days about a bill they know won't pass. **A2.**

Back to your layers

Wednesday: Some sun, cool. High 34-39. Low 24-29.

Thursday: Overcast. High 41-46. Low 32-37.

Sunrise: 6:51 Sunset: 6:54

Weather and Comics, G6-7.

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